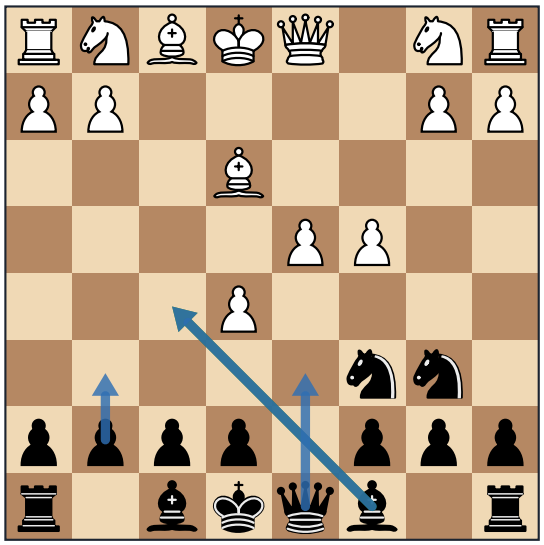
Alekhine Defense

ECO B02-B05 | 56 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 dxe5 6.fxe5 Nc6 7.Be3

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.68** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best: Bf5.

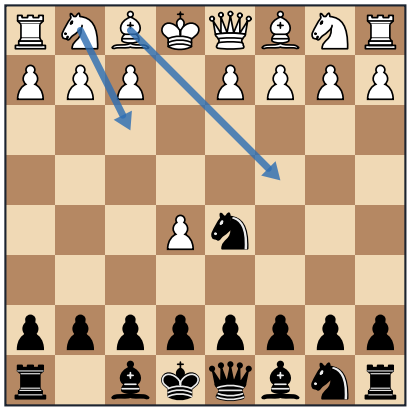
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 dxe5 6.fxe5 Nc6 7.Be3

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Hit e4. Develops the knight to f6.
2. e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2... Nd5	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
3. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3... d6	Support. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. c4	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... Nb6	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
5. f4	Austrian attack. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
5... dxe5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
6. fxe5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
6... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
7. Be3	Develops the bishop to e3.



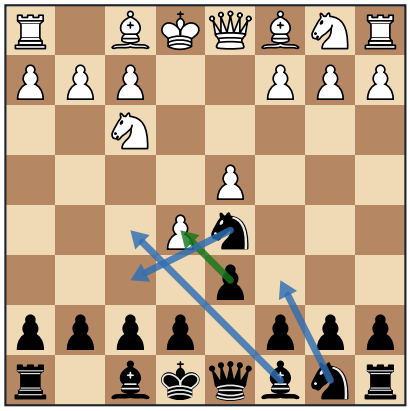
After 1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5



After 5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

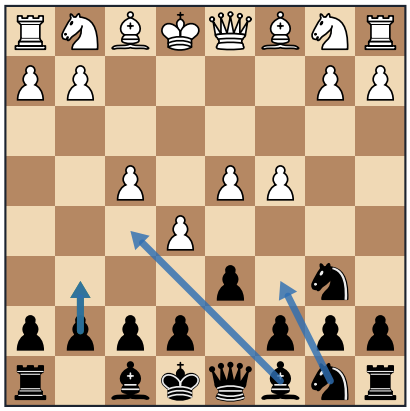


Position after the line

Modern Variation B04 | 12 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.46** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: dxe5.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Alekhine Gambit, Alburt Variation, Keres Variation, Larsen Variation

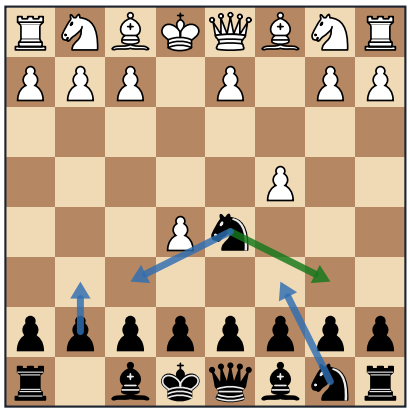


Position after the line

Four Pawns Attack B03 | 8 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4`

Stockfish: **+0.78** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: g6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Cambridge Gambit, Fianchetto Variation, Ilyin-Zhenevsky Variation, Korchnoi Variation



Position after the line

Two Pawns Attack B02 | 4 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4`

Stockfish: **+0.78** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Nb6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Lasker Variation, Mikenas Variation, Tate Variation



Position after the line

Hunt Variation B03 | 4 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.c5`

Stockfish: **-1.04** (clearly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: dxc5.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Lasker Simul Gambit, Matsukevich Gambit, Mikenas Gambit

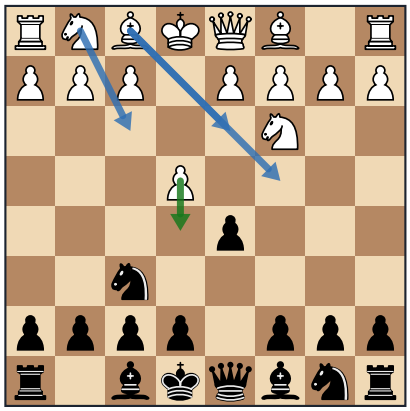


Position after the line

Mokele Mbembe B02 | 3 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Ne4`

Stockfish: **+1.49** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Modern Line, Vavra Defense



Position after the line

Scandinavian Variation B02 | 3 lines

`1.e4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5`

Stockfish: **+0.30** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: e5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Geschev Gambit, Myers Gambit

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Alekhine Defense (all lines)** — B02
  `1.e4 Nf6`
  - **Krejcik Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.Bc4`
    - **Krejcik Gambit** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nxe4 3.Bxf7`
  - **Maróczy Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.d3`
  - **Brooklyn Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Ng8`
    - **Everglades Variation** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Ng8 -> 3.d4 f5`
  - **Mokele Mbembe** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Ne4`
    - **Modern Line** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Ne4 -> 3.d4 f6`
    - **Vavra Defense** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Ne4 -> 3.d4 e6`
  - **Normal Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5`
  - **Scandinavian Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.Nc3 d5`
    - **Geschev Gambit** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 -> 3.exd5 c6`
    - **Myers Gambit** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 -> 3.d3 dxe4 4.Bg5`
  - **Buckley Attack** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.Na3`
  - **Sämisch Attack** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.Nc3`
  - **Two Pawns Attack** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4`
    - **Lasker Variation** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 -> 3...Nb6 4.c5`
    - **Tate Variation** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 -> 3...Nb6 4.a4`
    - **Mikenas Variation** — B02
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 -> 3...Nb6 4.c5 Nd5 5.Bc4 e6 6.Nc3 d6`
  - **Welling Variation** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.b3`
  - **O'Sullivan Gambit** — B03
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 b5`
  - **The Squirrel** — B02
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 Nf4`
  - **Balogh Variation** — B03
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Bc4`
  - **Modern Variation** — B04
    `1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3`
    - **Alburt Variation** — B04
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...g6`
    - **Larsen Variation** — B04
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...dxe5`
    - **Larsen-Haakert Variation** — B04
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Nc6`
    - **Main Line** — B05
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg4`
    - **Schmid Variation** — B04
      `1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Nb6`

- **Alekhine Variation** B05
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg4 5.c4
- **Panov Variation** B05
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg4 5.h3
- **Flohr Variation** B05
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg4 5.Be2 c6
- **Alekhine Gambit** B03
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.Nf3 Bg4 6.Be2
- **Vitolins Attack** B05
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg4 5.c4 Nb6 6.d5
- **Keres Variation** B04
  1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 -> 4...g6 5.Bc4 Nb6 6.Bb3 Bg7 7.a4
- **Spielmann Gambit** B02
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.e5 Nfd7 4.e6
- **Steiner Variation** B02
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 Nb6 4.b3
- **Exchange Variation** B03
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.exd6
  - **Voronezh Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.exd6 -> 5...cxd6 6.Nc3 g6 7.Be3 Bg7 8.Rc1 O-O 9.b3
  - **Karpov Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.exd6 -> 5...cxd6 6.Nc3 g6 7.h3 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O 9.Be2 Nc6 10.O-O Bf5 11.Bf4
- **Four Pawns Attack** B03
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4
  - **Cambridge Gambit** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...g5
  - **Fianchetto Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...g6
  - **Trifunovic Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...Bf5
  - **Main Line** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...dxe5 6.fxe5 Nc6 7.Be3
  - **Ilyin-Zhenevsky Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...dxe5 6.fxe5 Nc6 7.Nf3 Bg4 8.e6 fxe6 9.c5
  - **Korchnoi Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...dxe5 6.fxe5 Bf5 7.Nc3 e6 8.Nf3 Be7 9.Be2 O-O 10.O-O f6
  - **Tartakower Variation** B03
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 -> 5...dxe5 6.fxe5 Nc6 7.Be3 Bf5 8.Nc3 e6 9.Nf3 Qd7 10.Be2 O-O-O 11.…
- **Hunt Variation** B03
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.c5
  - **Lasker Simul Gambit** B02
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 Nb6 4.c5 Nd5 5.Bc4 e6 6.Nc3
  - **Matsukevich Gambit** B02
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 Nb6 4.c5 Nd5 5.Nc3 Nxc3 6.dxc3 d6 7.Bg5
  - **Mikenas Gambit** B02
    1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.c4 Nb6 4.c5 Nd5 5.Bc4 e6 6.Nc3 d6 7.Nxd5 exd5 8.Bxd5
- **Kmoch Variation** B02
  1.e4 Nf6 -> 2.e5 Nd5 3.Bc4 Nb6 4.Bb3 c5 5.d3

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4 dxe5
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.